From a Pile of Complaints to a Short List

A step-by-step plan for sorting out your father's care problems: nine actions, in order, with a line for who does each and by when.

The goal: the family's main concerns about your father's care are written down with an example for each, what your sister is carrying is on the page, and each issue you pick to deal with first has a next step and a name beside it.

Share the list with the family. Put a name and a day next to each action, and tick it when it's done. The order does more of the work than the speed.

ACTION	WHO	BY WHEN	DONE
1. Ask your father and each person in the family to name their main concerns. Write them in the words people used.			
2. Beside each concern, write one example: what happened, and on which day. If there isn't one, write “no example yet.”			
3. Mark what each concern involves: care, communication, paperwork or workload.			
4. Ask your sister, who does most of the day-to-day, which tasks can't continue as they are. Write down what she says, in her words.			
5. Where two people give different accounts of the same thing, write both. Don't choose between them.			
6. Mark the concerns the family can't settle itself, and who you'd take each one to: the doctor's office, the nurse, the pharmacist or your care consultant.			
7. Choose the concerns to talk about on the next family call.			
8. For each concern you chose, agree on one next action and who will follow up.			
9. Put everything else on an open-issues list, with a date to come back to it.			

You're done when

The main concerns are written down with an example for each, what your sister can and can't keep doing is on the page, and each issue you chose to deal with first has a next action or a person to contact beside it. The plan stops there. Looking into the concerns you marked for a professional, and any decision about your father's care, belong to the people who assess him.

If the plan stalls

- One call won't finish the list. A concern that stays open is still in order, as long as it's written down.

- If a step turns into a conversation about who is to blame, go back to step 2 and look for the example.
- A worry about your father's health today isn't a step on this plan. Call his doctor's office, and call emergency services for an emergency.

What this plan doesn't do

It organizes the family's part. It doesn't certify that your father is safe, authorize any change to his treatment, or stand in for the professional conversation it prepares you for.

Ready for the next step?

You've gone from a pile of complaints to a short list with a name beside each item. The care interview goes through your father's situation area by area with you, including the parts no one has complained about yet, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›